

Part II — The Interruption

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

Six figures arrive. The white working lights soften to amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The Door-keeper carries on the Boy-chair and sets it at the edge of the stage; the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — walk in behind him, the Step-Daughter already carrying the Child-bundle.

The Father asks for an author. The Manager, baffled, asks what kind of madmen have walked in off the street. The Step-Daughter taunts the Father and exposes him: a hundred francs in a back-room of a dressmaker's shop, a pale blue envelope on a little table, a transaction this town has agreed not to talk about. The Mother nearly faints — the Father lifts her veil against her will. The Father explains his marriage, the secretary he sent his wife away with, the wet-nurse for his son in the country. Every confession is contradicted by the next mouth that opens. The family is laid bare, and laid bare twice.

The actors of the company, who began this part as bored professionals, slowly recede to the wings. They are now an audience to the spectacle that has walked into their rehearsal — and they keep reacting to it, dry and delighted, so the comedy never quite leaves the room. The lighting tightens on the family; the rehearsal room dims around them. But the laughs keep landing even as the family settles inside its own argument, with no author in sight. The comedy is what carries the audience into the drama, not what gets cleared away to make room for it.

Playing note: the Father is not explaining — he is trying to survive judgment; play the long speeches as panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Caught between two identities, the actor inside the doorkeeper cannot quite suppress the dignity that makes the apology feel like a small act of resistance.

PLAYER 1 [*cap in hand — Player 1's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

Reflex authority: he hasn't looked up because nothing outside his rehearsal has earned attention yet.

THE MANAGER [*rudely*]. Eh? What is it?

The self-correction — timid hedge, then lifted chin — needs the Manager to know the failure was not his fault.

PLAYER 1 [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

Two targets, one breath: he scolds the door-keeper and pivots to the strangers without pausing, refusing to let the intrusion cost him a moment of control.

THE MANAGER [*without looking up*]. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! [*Turning to the Characters.*] Who are you, please? What do you want?

That hesitant 'actually' and the trailing ellipsis are a pre-emptive apology for a need the Father cannot help having.

THE FATHER [*coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed*]. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

He repeats the word back because repeating it is the only way to decide whether he really heard it.

THE MANAGER *[half angry, half amazed]*. An author? What author?

Any author will do — what the Father wants is not a particular writer but the function of authorship: a witness who will hold their story.

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

Practical logic used as a door-slam, unaware it also names the Characters' deepest wound: no work exists, no form, for what they carry.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

She hijacks the Father's opening move and converts it into a commercial pitch, undercutting him and the theatre's self-importance in a single breath.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]*. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

Communal offence-taking bonds the actors together — shared indignation is easier than sitting with the grain of truth inside the taunt.

PLAYER 3 *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh — do you hear that?

The self-correction from 'perfectly' to 'adequately' is the whole wound: vanity punctured in real time, in front of his own company.

PLAYER 1 *[stung; it lands because it is half true]*. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

Two negotiations running at once — he reaches for the Manager through logic while trying to restrain the Step-Daughter — and both are failing.

THE FATHER *[to Step-Daughter]*. Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To Manager.]* unless you would be willing...

'Budget' alongside 'time' demotes the Characters' claim from existential to administrative: a bureaucrat's defence against the uncanny.

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

His 'for Heaven's sake' is genuine horror at being misread as comic; the weight of the drama must be felt before any argument can begin.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

A dare wrapped in a promise: she knows their story is dangerous and bets his theatrical greed will override his caution.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

Bundling them with 'our own' mad people accidentally concedes that a theatre is already full of controlled unreality.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

He stops theorising and dares the Manager with his own trade: making invented things true is the actor's job — and the Six are already true; they lack only a stage.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer]*. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

Applause as self-soothing: the company rescues its collective ego by cheering a speech about immortal works that sidesteps the mirror being held up.

THE MANAGER *[interpreting the rising anger of the Company]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The Actors, satisfied, applaud their Manager.]*

Agreeing so completely becomes an ambush — his embrace of their claim reveals that fictional characters are more honest than the living people in the room.

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The Actors look at one another in amazement.]*

A knife slipped between the Father's ribs: she collapses his grand philosophy into the personal history only she was forced to witness.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

The Father has moved faster than the conversation can follow — a philosopher outpacing a room that still believes it is in charge.

THE MANAGER. But what do you mean? Before, you said...

He pulls the abstraction back into reach: imagination makes the invisible visible — still pleading his existence, but now in words a listener can hold.

THE FATHER. No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

A small surrender disguised as pragmatism: he has stopped trying to evict them and is now, despite himself, following the thread.

THE MANAGER. Very well, — but where does all this take us?

He strips the metaphysics to the bone — not a lecture but a plea: they exist, fully, and have only been denied a place to do it.

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

Feigned dismay is the first crack of genuine engagement: he has begun playing with the idea even as he pretends only to mock it.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

Triumphant but premature — the laughter that follows shows he has won the argument in his own head while losing the room entirely.

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[Manager and Actors burst out laughing.]*

He deploys the Mother's silent, veiled grief as visual evidence, redirecting attention from the absurdity of their arrival to its pathos.

THE FATHER *[hurt]*. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

Ordering them out is also an admission: he cannot simply ignore people who have already made ignoring them impossible.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! *[To Property Man.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

For the Characters, expulsion is not an inconvenience but an existential threat — his repeated 'no, no' is almost physical resistance.

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

Shouting is all he has left; the rational argument has escaped him and only volume remains.

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

Retreating into witty self-regard — the lunch joke, the class marker — rather than admitting the Characters have genuinely unsettled him.

PLAYER 1. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

He draws the actors' own professional experience as his evidence: if they can inhabit fictional lives, why can't fictional lives seek bodies to inhabit?

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the Prompter's box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

'Side-tracked' is the calmest and most devastating word in the scene — it names abandonment as administrative failure, stripping away all sentiment.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards Manager, eyes level, not smiling]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

Two names that outlived their makers thrown against his own fate: finished characters live forever; the Six were made alive and then left with nowhere to be.

THE FATHER *[to the Manager]*. Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

Her 'many times' tells us the Father's grief has become a rehearsed performance for strangers — she has been his unwilling audience all along.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, to no one in particular]*. He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

'Quite all right' is exhausted concession wearing the mask of politeness; he has stopped fighting the philosophy and just wants a practical answer.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

Three words that compress the Characters' entire ontological need into something pre-rational — not to tell their story, not to be remembered, simply to exist.

THE FATHER. We want to live.

Sardonic as it sounds, 'For Eternity?' is his first genuine imaginative engagement: the absurdity has caught him before he can stop it.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

'Only for a moment... in you' is the most intimate request in the play — not an audience but an incarnation, asking actors to become vessels.

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

'As if there were room' is professional jealousy dressed as metaphysics — she is protecting her status, not making a philosophical point.

PLAYER 2 *[chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1]*. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

He is losing control of the room and pivots to the Manager as his last practical authority — desperation dressed as organisational energy.

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the Manager.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon concert it among ourselves.

The list of genres ends with honest self-deprecation about the revue, a brief human moment before he retreats behind gatekeeping.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to concert? We don't go in for concerts here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

Structurally identical to line 48, the 'Exactly!' seizes any opening as confirmation, turning the Manager's dismissal into an unwitting invitation.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

A book is something he can hold, schedule, control — demanding one exposes the limits of a medium that cannot stage what has no material form.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

Asking the actors to trust the living body over the written text is precisely what actors dread and desire in equal measure.

THE FATHER. It is in us! *[The Actors laugh.]* The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

She cuts his communal 'our' down to 'his': she does not share the passion — she is its object and its casualty.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at him]*. His passion. Always the word *passion*.

The hand held one beat too long on his shoulder is a public staging of the private act that shames them both; she weaponises the touch she cannot take back.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[crossing behind the Father, voice flat]*. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*. *[Places a deliberate hand on the Father's shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.]*

Fear of exposure, not moral outrage: her cold laugh dismantles the philosophical dignity he has spent the whole scene constructing.

THE FATHER [*angrily*]. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

A controlled detonation — she announces her orphan status and immediately punctures its pathos with cabaret, refusing to let anyone pity her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. [Sings and then dances Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou.]*

Entertainment has overridden judgment: the theatre's reflex to spectacle makes them forget, for one unguarded moment, that they were contemptuous.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

His alarm at her sanity is really alarm at his own response — he wants order restored precisely because the song nearly worked on him.

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! [*Turning to the **Father** in consternation.*] Is she mad?

Conceding what he cannot explain, the Leading Man lets theatrical metrics slip away and simply admits she has something he cannot measure.

PLAYER 1 [*to Player 2, won over*]. She has more stage presence than the second act. I'll say that.

Madness would be a mercy — the Father refuses it because the safer category would let her stop being right.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

She seizes the plot's wheel entirely, mapping every turn in advance to leave the Father no corner of the story he can claim.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*to Manager*]. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here [*Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.*] does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me [*Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.*], I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool [*Indicates the Son.*]. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. [*Goes to the Mother and embraces her.*] And he won't even recognise her as his mother. Wretch.

Her body speaks before language can: the arms pulling both children close, then falling, say what no sentence of hers has managed.

THE MOTHER [*to the **Manager**; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright*]. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... [*She grows faint and is about to fall.*] Oh God!

Chivalry deployed as staging — he rushes forward to help and, in the same motion, casts himself as the scene's moral anchor.

THE FATHER [*coming forward to support her as do some of the **Actors***]. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

Unable to distinguish grief from theatre, the Actors reach for the only category they know and ask whether the collapse is real.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

He calls for the chair and is already directing — the practical crisis and the scene he wants to shape are, for him, the same thing.

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! [*One of the **Actors** brings a chair, the **Others** proffer assistance. The **Mother** tries to prevent the **Father** from lifting the veil which covers her face.*]

Forcing the Mother's face into public view, he turns her pain into an exhibit that proves his own suffering.

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

Her 'no' is not modesty; the veil is the last membrane between a private wound and the spectacle the Father is building around her.

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

Lifting the veil, he borrows her body as evidence — the same appropriation that defined the marriage he is now narrating.

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

Turning to the Manager, she names for the first time exactly what she cannot bear: being made into testimony in someone else's argument.

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

Reaching for the tidiest domestic category he knows, the Manager hopes 'wife' or 'widow' will restore the authority this family is stripping from him.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife? *[To the Father.]*

Flat confirmation coated in possessive pride — he claims her still, without noticing that the claim convicts him.

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

The laugh is a defence: the Actors grab the logical absurdity to avoid looking at the emotional reality it floats on top of.

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The Actors find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

He needs the room solemn because laughter dissolves the gravity in which his reframing of events can take hold.

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

The cry escapes before she can catch it; the hand at her mouth shows the years of practice she has had doing exactly that.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

Mourning etiquette deployed as irony — 'most respectable' strips the black clothes of every comfort they were meant to provide.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

Reclassifying the Mother as a function rather than a person, he erases her desire so that only his philosophical architecture remains standing.

THE FATHER. He isn't here, you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

*At the word children, the **Mother's** arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.*

Breaking her habitual silence, she shifts the grammar from passive to active — 'he gave me' — and for the first time holds the story in her own hands.

THE MOTHER. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? *[To the Company.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

A reflex of loyalty more than an argument; she is fighting a different battle from the Mother and does not notice the difference.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

The denial lands on her body before her mind can form a rebuttal; she echoes it back as a question, still absorbing the blow.

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true, isn't it?

Triple repetition is not emphasis — she is persuading herself as much as the room, and the effort shows.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, it isn't true, it just isn't true.

Genuine anguish, not rhetoric: how can a daughter who was not yet born claim authority over what the mother lived and endured.

THE MOTHER. And what can you know about it?

Her defence of the Father is also self-defence — absolving him keeps the Son's indifference inexcusable and the family wound permanently open.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To Manager.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the Son.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he *[Indicates the Father.]* made her do so.

One glance upward toward the Son who does not return it, one immediate retreat: the whole arc of maternal failure compressed into a stage direction.

THE MOTHER *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor].* He forced me to it. *[Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the Son. He does not look back. She lowers them again.]* And I call God to witness it. *[To the Manager, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the Father.]* if it isn't true. *Let him speak.* You *[To the Step-Daughter.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

The dead father's tenderness is wielded as a weapon; happiness in that house becomes evidence against the Mother's claim of coercion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

Unable to lie about the happiness, she concedes complexity — and the honesty costs her the argument before she can finish the sentence.

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

Shaking the empty coat as if the dead man could still testify, she lets grief show through the violence of the gesture.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

Still loyal to the dead man's memory, she draws a careful line between the act of leaving and any passion that might have excused it.

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

Three words stripped of all philosophical scaffolding — the Father's brevity here is more damning than any speech he has delivered.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

His sentence dies when his eyes reach the Mother; real pain crosses into the theatre space and the appetite for spectacle curdles into something else.

PLAYER 1 *[to the Company, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the Mother, and the end of the sentence does not arrive].* What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

Quietly, without irony, she marks the inversion: the professionals have been demoted and the family they cannot perform for has become the show.

PLAYER 2 *[lower now].* We are the audience this time.

One phrase landing in silence does what a full sentence could not — the absence of laughter proves the normal social release has been shut down.

PLAYER 3 *[quietly, the pencil not moving].* For once. *[Nobody laughs.]*

Leaning forward the way an audience member does when they have stopped pretending not to care, the sceptic is becoming a witness against his will.

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen].* Let's hear them out. Listen!

Pre-emptive ridicule is the Son's only weapon: label the philosophy fast enough and perhaps it will not seduce the room before he can stop it.

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

Buried inside the attack is the most honest thing he says — 'an expression I found to excuse myself' — and he covers it immediately with contempt.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. *[To the **Manager**.]* He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

Monotone repetition performs the very thing it accuses; he too uses a word as a wall to keep the Father's reality at arm's length.

THE SON *[without looking up]*. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

Universalising his failure into everyone's condition, he redistributes guilt until no single person can be held to account for anything specific.

THE FATHER. Phrases! Isn't everyone consoled when faced with a trouble or fact he doesn't understand, by a word, some simple word, which tells us nothing and yet calms us?

Two words cut through the whole edifice: she names remorse as the most self-serving consolation word of all, the one that costs least.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

His insistence that he went beyond words is a setup — the hundred francs is the action he substituted for feeling, and it is coming.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

Making the abstraction sordid and exact, she times the detail of the money to destroy whatever sympathy the Father has carefully built.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the **Actors**.]*

His disgust at her exposure mirrors his own refusal to confront the family's wound; what he calls vile, he also calls too close to home.

THE SON *[to the **Step-Daughter**]*. This is vile.

With forensic precision she catalogues the shop, forcing the polite euphemism 'robes et manteaux' to carry its real cargo of exploitation and exchange.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

*As the shop is named, the **Mother** draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.*

The unpaid money becomes a moral paradox: the Father is guilty of the intention even though the act was interrupted, desire proven by the attempt.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

Compressed into one ironic laugh: bitterness, survivor relief, and self-contempt — a sound that has nowhere respectable to land.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[Laughs ironically.]*

She turns the Child's face away before she speaks; the words are addressed inward, a reflex to shield innocence from shame already filling the room.

THE MOTHER *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room]*. Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The **Step-Daughter's** laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

Claiming ownership of the shame and inverting it into power, she reconstructs the room so exactly that memory becomes re-enactment and the Father cannot intervene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does. [*Indicating Father.*]

Pirandello plants the Manager here as a surrogate for the audience — confusion on stage to licence confusion in the house.

THE MANAGER [*the audience's confusion, on stage*]. I don't understand this at all.

Sweating slightly, visibly recovering — the composure is the tell; guilt shows not in the fall but in the effort of repair.

THE FATHER [*he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble*]. Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

Permission granted with contempt already baked in: she knows exactly what his explanation will do and what it will quietly leave out.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

He compresses his whole defence into an alibi: language itself betrays him, so every attempt to explain the wound only deepens the charge against him.

THE FATHER. Words are the whole trouble. I say one thing, she hears another. I try to explain myself — and the explanation becomes another crime.

Three words outweigh all his speeches; the simplest statement is the one that has been waiting longest in the room to be said.

THE MOTHER. But you drove me away.

He needs the witnesses to hear the denial more than he needs the Mother to believe it; disbelief is directed outward, not inward.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

'A poor woman, nothing' — she was married into disappearance long before she was sent away, and names it without bitterness.

THE MOTHER [*looking at the floor between them*]. You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir [*To Manager.*] — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

The spread arms are the gesture of a man who has always considered himself misunderstood — but the silence that follows shows no one is rushing to prove him right.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. [*He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.*] You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. [*Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.*] She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

Away from feelings and toward consequence: she measures intelligence by the damage it has done, not the depth at which it operates.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

A last philosophical escape hatch — and the stage direction that immediately follows, vanity breaking into the room, punctures it before it closes.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? [*At this point the **Leading Lady** who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the **Leading Man** flirting with the **Step-Daughter**, comes forward and says to the **Manager**.*]

Impatience turns professional: she mocks the intrusion to yank the room back toward the work she was actually hired to do.

PLAYER 2. Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

Caught between duty and a fascination he won't yet name, he buys time with the most non-committal sentence available.

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

'Educational' is the Ingénue's polite demotion — she files the Characters under specimen rather than competition.

PLAYER 1 *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; Player 1's voice is showing]*. Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

Rent against philosophy: she plants her flag on the side of labour and recruits Leading Man with a glance.

PLAYER 2. Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at **Leading Man**.]*

Seating himself while issuing the command, he accepts — provisionally — the role of audience.

THE MANAGER *[to **Father**]*. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

Generous patron comes first in the Father's account; the engineering of the arrangement comes later, buried under sympathy.

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the **Mother**.]* They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

Four words and the philanthropy collapses — she names the desire he has been wrapping in euphemism.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

A man who cannot tolerate intimacy that excludes him: the 'constant rage' at silent glances is control dressed as suffering.

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage — to exasperate me beyond measure.

The obvious question is a trap the Father has been waiting for — it unlocks the next, more damaging, revelation.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

Pity and contempt occupy the same word: he pictures the Mother as a pet, not a person.

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

Not agreement — the sound of someone enduring a version of her own story that has been taken from her.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

He turns to her for corroboration, weaponising her silence and forcing her into the impossible position of witness against herself.

THE FATHER *[suddenly turning to the **Mother**]*. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

She corrects the sequence — the son was taken first, making every subsequent act of 'liberation' a compounded dispossession.

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

Country air and health name the child's benefit while burying the Mother's loss inside a middle-class rationalisation.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

Two words and a pointed finger: the Son's visible coldness is the evidence already in the room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[pointing at him, no smile]*. As one can see.

Wet nurse, weak mother, moral aspirations — he can only confess inside an excuse, every admission cushioned by the next.

THE FATHER *[quickly]*. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

A stage director's instinct cuts through: story is what the theatre can use, not philosophy.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

'Regular customer' lands as a court verdict, converting abstract moral aspiration into a transaction with a price and an address.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

The theatre professional senses he has wandered into something that cannot be rehearsed away — and shifts in his seat.

PLAYER 1 *[shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]*. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

'Fool!' is self-directed anger redirected outward; the elaborate speech that follows tries to turn contradiction into virtue.

THE FATHER *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]*. Fool! That is the proof that I am a man. This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a *live* man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman *[Indicating the Mother.]* any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.

Flat repetition of 'He calls it pity' is deliberate deadpan — she lets the word echo in the room until it rots.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[flat, into the room]*. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

The dash is the hinge: she cannot finish because the act of being turned out still has no proper name for her.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

'Well provided for' is a bookkeeper's phrase hiding a transaction — he paid her off and calls the currency freedom.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

Three words strip the Father's altruism to its skeleton: the liberation was always primarily his.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

Crossed arms betray the self-consciousness of a man composing himself mid-lie as he reframes surveillance of her new family as tenderness.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine — I have never once doubted it. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? Out of pure interest in you, with no base motive in it, I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

She delivers the memory to the room, not to the Father — the audience becomes the jury, not him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

'Infamous' is the word of a man afraid the image is true rather than certain it is false.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

Quiet 'Why?' is the cruelest possible response — she refuses him even the dignity of a denial to push against.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

'Dazed fly' and the estranged Son together expose the surveillance: he was filling a vacuum he was responsible for creating.

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. This boy here *[Indicating the Son.]* was educated away from home; when he came back, he seemed to me to be no more mine. With no mother between him and me, he grew up apart, on his own, with no tie of intellect or affection. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

Even the cynics are drawn in — the mock-scholarly notepad is the company losing its ironic distance against its professional will.

PLAYER 2 *[the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad]*. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

Forensic calm is more damning than outrage: each detail — hat, bouquet, straw — is a piece of evidence she has long catalogued.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street and smile at me, wave his hand like this. I looked at him, doubtful, wondering who he might be. I told my mother, who guessed at once. *[The Mother agrees with a nod.]* Then she wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again — looking so ridiculous — with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers, all for me.

'Discursive' is the dramaturg's complaint: the story is real but shapeless, and the theatre needs a scene, not a deposition.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

Contempt for the Father's self-dramatisation and for the entire theatrical frame that flatters everyone's pain into narrative.

THE SON *[turning his face away from the Father]*. Literature. Literature.

Life, passion — his deepest vanity surfaces: suffering too real for fiction, even as he performs it for the room.

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

'It won't act' is the theatre's verdict on raw experience: what cannot be shaped for an audience has no place on stage.

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

He pre-emptively edits his own story for stagability, deciding which parts — the stalking, the gifts — to suppress.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She *[Pointing to the Step-Daughter.]*, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

Completing his sentence is an act of possession — she will not let him control even the grammar of her own transformation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the skirt down past the knee!

A connoisseur's excitement about his own catastrophe: guilt turned into a selling point for the drama he is pitching.

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

The biological father's death is stated as fact, not grief — it is simply the door through which disaster entered.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

The pointing gesture 'immediately regretted' catches his habit of using the Mother as exhibit before he can stop himself.

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. *[A small pointing gesture toward the Mother, immediately regretted.]* She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

Not rhetorical — the genuine bewilderment of a woman for whom his 'sentiment' was always invisible behind his actions.

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?

He converts the Mother's incomprehension into her failure, as if emotional literacy were a duty she breached rather than a code he kept secret.

THE FATHER. That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments.

Her unfinished sentence holds the entire weight of the years he is glossing — time and event are her evidence, not his feeling.

THE MOTHER. After so many years apart, and all that had happened...

'Naturally' arrives before he can stop it and does more damage than the rest of the speech: it confesses that his interest was always conditional.

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, *[the word arrives before he can stop it]* naturally, my interest dwindled. *[The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.]* But the drama culminated, unforeseen, on their return — when I was driven by the loneliness that still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man who is alone, and too proud for the shabby, easy comforts. Not old enough to do without company. Not young enough to seek it without shame. It is worse than misery. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. *[A beat. He has to swallow.]* One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.

The whispered rudeness is the company's id speaking — the speech has stripped decorum and what remains is the audience's unspeakable private reaction.

PLAYER 1 *[under his breath, to Player 3].* I have several questions. None of them are polite.

Nine words answer his whole theory of secret shame: the courage he claims is impunity dressed as honesty.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

His theory of mutual blindness is an absolution factory — social hypocrisy becomes a system that makes him merely its most honest member.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But he is like all the others — he only admits, with the light of intelligence, the plain shame in all of us that most men prefer to close their eyes upon. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

She names what his system cannot accommodate: the woman who no longer needs to look away, who sees clearly and is disgusted.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

'Discussion' is his word for what belongs in the rehearsal room — he wants the wound itself, not the wound's theory.

THE MANAGER. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

The sack metaphor is his most polished evasion — he aestheticises a request for sympathy into a theory of knowledge.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she *[Pointing to the Mother.]* had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

A guided tour of the apparatus of respectable exploitation — she names the machine before she names what it processed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

An appeal to credibility from the least credible witness to her own victimisation.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

Told with cold precision — she has narrated the torn-dress scheme to herself many times, assembling the proof that the trap was designed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

Steering toward the scene, he has accepted his role as dramaturg of a real catastrophe.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

'Superb!' is pure theatrical aggression — she dares the Manager to stage the scene that will destroy the Father's remaining dignity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

Fixing the timeline before the Step-Daughter can: 'then' arrives in place of any moral word.

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

'Almost in time' is the blade: it tells the room that 'in time' is the Father's revision, not the truth.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

Repeating 'in time' twice is a man trying to win a verdict by sheer repetition; 'I cannot look her in the face' is the only honest thing he says.

THE FATHER *[crying out]*. No — in time. *In time*. Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

Contempt sharpens into refusal: she won't play modest young miss after Madame Pace's room, and no amount of the Father's moral vocabulary can make her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

His defence reduced to its nerve — do not let one moment be the whole of me — even as the room, the table, the envelope make that moment impossible to outrun.

THE FATHER. One moment is not a whole man. But she wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

Forensic and final: she answers his plea with the one fact it cannot survive — nobody made him walk into that shop.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[flat]*. You walked into that room by yourself.

A quiet puncture: naming it a confession collapses the Father's elaborate self-defence into the one word he spent the whole speech avoiding.

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

Stillness as refusal — his body simply won't enter the scene, the only sovereignty left to a son who has been handed a role he never agreed to play.

THE SON *[hands in his pockets, body not moving]*. Leave me alone. I don't come into this.

Not a question but a demand: the Father needs the Son onstage to complete his tableau and cannot accept that a character might simply walk off the stage.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

Being "mixed up" with them feels contaminating; the Son is fighting to keep the family story from adhering to him like a stain he can never wash off.

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

Class irony turned to weapon: she calls herself vulgar to expose his pretension, then conscripts the Manager as witness to a shaming the Son cannot sidestep.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

One syllable of disbelief that is not innocence — it's an instinct to contest the record before it hardens into fact against him.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

An indictment reframed as domestic history: "mistress of the house" reclaims a dignity the Son's cold contempt had already stripped from her family.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — you! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. I'd like Mr. Manager to witness certain scenes between him and me. He says I have tyrannised. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

Switching from accused to narrator, he repaints the Step-Daughter as threatening and mercenary — a defence against the charge of cruelty that makes him sound crueller.

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. But imagine, gentlemen, the position of a son who sees arrive one day at his home a young woman of impudent bearing, asking for his father — with whom, who knows what business she has. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there. He has to watch her treat his father in an equivocal and confidential manner. She asks him for money — in a way that lets one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

Calm, almost proud admission; acknowledging the debt to the Mother positions him as honourable and quietly blunts the Son's implicit charge of exploitation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

"Unrealised" becomes both self-diagnosis and escape hatch: name yourself incomplete and no complete action — no complete guilt — can ever be pinned to you.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

He senses the philosophical leverage in the Son's self-erasure and starts to turn it back on him — but the trap closes before he can finish the sentence.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

Absent fathering forfeits the right to define a child; the counter-attack shifts the ground from what he is to who on earth has the authority to say so.

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me?

The cold cracks for one line — he names the part forced on him: the family needs an innocent to blame, and he is it.

THE SON [*the one time the cold cracks*]. You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

The Mother's tears are pointed at the Manager like an exhibit; genuine pain is being stage-managed in front of a stage manager, and nobody blinks.

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... *[Pointing out the **Mother** to the **Manager**.]* See, she's crying!

Three words of flat contempt; by refusing the Mother's grief as weakness, she shows how completely she has shut herself to anything that resembles softness.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at the **Mother**].* Like a fool.

The Boy's silence becomes ammunition: the Father turns a mute child's suffering into dramatic argument, weaponising his pain to pressure the Son.

THE FATHER *[indicating Step-Daughter].* She can't stand him, you know. *[Then referring again to the Son.]* He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. Possibly his situation is the most painful of all. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. *[In confidence.]* The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

Brutal pragmatism laid bare — inconvenient bodies, especially children's, are simply cut; the stage keeps only what it can use.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

He stops explaining and lets the ending haunt — the children gone, a family left in one house unable to belong to one another, the wound the whole play will circle.

THE FATHER. The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.